

Central and South America

The first civilizations of central and southern America began to emerge around 2600 BCE. First established c.1400 BCE, the Olmecs wrote in hieroglyphics and developed a sophisticated style of stone sculpture. They are most famous for their mysterious, monumental 3-metre (9-ft) stone male heads with fleshy cheeks and flat noses. The Maya built most of their cities between 200–900 CE, and adorned them with paintings, carvings, ceramics, figurines and clay and stucco models. Most art, featuring flat, stylized imagery and hieroglyphs, was commissioned by kings.

Emerging in c.1200 CE in the mountains of Peru, the Inca civilization standardized religious art so it could be replicated across their empire. Simple geometric forms and stylized animals appeared in ceramics, wood carvings, textiles and metalwork. The Aztecs, meanwhile, emerged in c.1325 CE in Mexico. Their art developed from a mix of influences and beliefs, including the Olmecs, who inspired monumental stone sculpture. They also adorned their architecture, pottery and metalwork with figures, animals, plants and gods.



Olmec head, c.1000 BCE